

Do we need 'Big Brother' watching us?

Should corporates monitor employees' Net usage? Anil Patrick R. speaks with representatives of Bharat Petroleum and Dishnet DSL on whether it violates the individual's right to privacy

Monitoring employees' Internet usage should be enforced by every organisation. This is highly beneficial for smooth operations. If an organisation is providing Internet access to employees, it is solely for work purposes. If an employee uses the Net for personal reasons, it is a waste of available resources.

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Yet another problem is chatting, which is a major waste of time and bandwidth. Employees can get so addicted to chatting that work is completely neglected. Chatting is completely off limits in our organisation. Similar is the case when employees use the company's e-mail facility for personal purposes. The endless chain of forwarded e-mail can crash the mail server and this is something every organisation can do

"If an employee uses the Internet for personal purposes, it is a waste of available resources"

As a pioneering company providing Internet access, we believe that monitoring employees' Internet access is not an ethical practice. We do not monitor Internet usage by employees for various reasons.

Reading an employee's e-mail is just like opening and reading one of his letters. Every individual has a right to privacy and this basic right is compromised when an organisation gets involved in monitoring.

"The individual's privacy is compromised when an organisation monitors the Net usage of its employees"

enough channels open for efficient communication and constant learning will there be efficient employees.

If Internet usage is monitored, what is the difference between this revolutionary medium and the old channels of communication? Tracking what your employee does on the Internet is just like tapping

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There are several aspects to this issue. Productivity of the employee suffers when he browses the Internet for purposes other than work. Surfing of sites with sexually explicit content is a major problem, which can completely disrupt employee morale and destroy productivity.

Downloading of objectionable material and illegal software can cause severe bandwidth problems. It can also lead the organisation into major legal hassles. We have monitoring software to ensure that no unwanted sites are visited by employees.

without. We have enforced scanning of e-mail for unwanted content to avoid such problems. If an employee is found to have misused the facility, he is warned.

Security is a major problem as well. When Internet usage is not monitored, it is possible that confidential internal information could be leaked out. Other problems such as viruses and internal hacking attempts are also possible.

All these factors made us enforce monitoring of Internet usage by employees. We believe that it is a highly beneficial practice for the organisation. ■

Yet another big issue is that of trust. An organisation can attain success only if there exists complete trust between the management and the employees. Our employees are the essence of our organisation. If we monitor Internet usage, we are breaking that bond of trust. Our employees understand how to use the Internet judiciously, and we don't want to question their integrity by monitoring their Net usage.

The Internet has ushered in an era of efficient and cheap access to information. Knowledge is power. Only if there are

into a phone line to overhear a conversation. Would all the advocates for Internet monitoring in offices indulge in tapping employees' phone lines as well? I don't think so. Then why should we monitor what our colleagues are doing on the Net? This type of 'Big brother is watching!' scenario only tends to demoralise employees. It also tends to breed a tendency to break the system. Let the Internet be what it is—the best and cheapest method of access to information. There is no need to put constraints on the basic human right to communication and information. ■

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